Harris and Me

By Gary Paulsen

(Ch. 10 ***(Pg 127-134)*** *- In which I discover love only to have my heart broken and in revenge I fry Harris's business)*

"I ain't gonna do it."

Harris stood by the side of the barn, looking at the wire that came from an insulator near the door and led out into the pasture.

The chickens hit it a few times, squawking and jumping with feathers flying, and even Buzzer, [the dog], accidently brushed the wire. When it popped him he took it as an attack and went after it, which of course made it worse and made him more angry so that he attacked harder, biting and clawing at the wire until finally he admitted defeat and walked away from the fence. Every hair on his body was straight out and I believe if anybody had crossed him right then he would have killed.

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It was while Buzzer was fighting the wire that the idea came. We had tried touching it with the backs of our fingers and pieces of grass but the results were inconclusive. I had always been of a scientific nature, believed in the worth of experiments, and I wondered what would happen - watching Buzzer and the fence at war - if somebody actually peed on the wire.

Specifically, I wondered what would happen if ***Harris*** peed on the wire.

INTRODUCTION

Have you ever been betrayed by someone? Usually it's by people we don't get along with, but sometimes we are bested by friends. In that situation, how do you retaliate? In this selection, Harris and Me by Gary Paulsen, the 11-year old narrator is madly in love with Harris's cousin, Elaine. Harris, seeing that Elaine is going to take his best friend's focus away from Harris during their summer, ruins the chances of the lovebirds getting together. So what is a friend to do? Why seek revenge, of course! Harris and Me by Gary Paulsen.

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I knew it would not be an easy experiment to conduct and set about doing it carefully. The subject would be reluctant - downright negative, as it turned out - and there would have to be some form of inducement so attractive that it would overcome the reluctance.

As it happened I had the "dourty peectures." *(dirty pictures)*

The power of these pictures to control and induce were beyond question. I believe if given enough of them Harris would have walked into a bonfire - indeed, I would have done the same thing. The quality of the pictures wasn't great. They were black-and-white and small and grainy. But they worked. It was impossible to look at them and still breathe correctly. My dilemma was mostly one of quantity. I knew I could get the experiment to work, but with how much effort?

How many pictures would it take?

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I had, altogether, seven of them and since I was interested in them myself - purely from an artistic viewpoint, of course - I didn't want to completely deplete the collection.

I offered Harris one picture. It was not the best picture - the best picture I wouldn't have released if Harris had bitten the wire and hung on with his mouth (something I considered suggesting when I remembered what he had done with the first love of my life) - but it was a good picture: accurate in detail, fundamentally sound as far as composition and educational benefits were concerned, and far reaching in its ability to promote advanced stages of hyperventilation.

HARRIS: "Nope. I ain't gonna do it."

But his refusal was soft. I could sense the weakness in it and I countered. The picture I'd offered, plus one other, the one where it was possible to See It All.

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HARRIS: "Well…"

NARRATOR: *(to audience)* I had him. *(To Harris)* "First the rules."

HARRIS: "What rules?"

NARRATOR: "You have to pee right on the wire - not just pass over it - and you have to pee on it long enough to get the surge. Otherwise it's not a deal."

HARRIS: *(studying the wire)* "That thing put a sow on her knees…"

NARRATOR: *(shaking his head)* "She was off balance. Besides, two of the pictures for your very own - that's a good swap."

HARRIS: *(thinking for a minute, then a heavy sigh)* "All right. Go get the pictures."

NARRATOR: *(To Harris)* "I've got them. *(Showing him the pictures)* So go ahead - pee on it." *(To audience)* He unbuttoned his fly on his bibs and took

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his business out, then stood there, frowning. *(To Harris)* "What's the matter?"

HARRIS: "It don't work. Nothing's coming out."

NARRATOR: "Push a little."

HARRIS: "I am. It's scared. It don't want to do it."

NARRATOR: "If you don't pee on the wire, the deal is off."

HARRIS: "It's like it knows what's coming and don't want to do it."

NARRATOR: "Two pictures…"

HARRIS: "I'll have to lie to it."

NARRATOR: "Lie to what?"

HARRIS: "My business. I'll just have to lie to it and start peeing over here, then swing around, make the dumb thing think everything is all right."

NARRATOR: *(to audience)* He turned sideways, aimed away from the fence, and in a moment it started. *(to Harris)* "So turn. Before it's done!"

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HARRIS: "It ain't that easy. Something in me won't let it happen…"

NARRATOR: "Ahh heck, you're going to run out."

HARRIS: "No, I'm holding her back. Here, now…"

He turned slowly until the stream of urine was only inches away from the wire, hung there for a second, then hit the wire.

HARRIS: "There, now are you hap -----"

Later I would come to know a great deal about electrical things. I would understand that water is an excellent conductor of electrical energy but that urine, with its higher mineral content, is even better and what Harris did amounted to hooking a copper wire from his business to the electric fence.

The results were immediate, and everything I would have hoped for from a standpoint of scientific observation, not to mention revenge.

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In a massive reaction every muscle in Harris's body convulsively contracted, jerking like a giant spring had tightened inside him.

He went stiff as a poker, then soared up and over backward in a complete flip, arcing a stream that caught the afternoon sun so I swore I could see a rainbow in it.

Nor did the spectacle end when he hit the ground. He landed on his side, both legs pumping, then sprung to his feet, running in tight circles holding himself and hissing:

HARRIS: "Oh-God-oh-God-oh-God-oh…."

All in all it was well worth the investment and when he finally settled, leaning against the barn wall holding his business, panting loudly, I reached under my shirt to give him the two pictures.

It was not to be, and the exact responsibility of who owed whom pictures would plague us the rest of the summer and perhaps does yet.

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As I held the pictures toward Harris and he released his groin long enough to reach for them a shadow fell over us and I turned to see Louie, [the farmhand] standing there.

He reached down with a crooked, filthy hand and took the pictures, held them up to the light, smiled toothlessly, and walked away toward the granary, putting the pictures in the top pocket of his bibs.

HARRIS: "Damn. You owe me two pictures."

NARRATOR: "It wasn't my fault. I held them out to you. Louie took them."

HARRIS: "They wasn't halfway. They wasn't even close to halfway."

NARRATOR: "They were over halfway."

HARRIS: "You liar."

NARRATOR: "I'm not lying. I handed the pictures over to you and you were reaching for them when Louie grabbed them. I did what I was supposed to do."

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HARRIS: "***You*** did?! *(grimacing in pain)* ***I*** peed on the wire…"

Later that night, lying in bed in the darkened room, I remembered him hitting the wire and started laughing.

HARRIS: "It ain't funny. I'm all swoll up. It's like my business was hit by lightning."

NARRATOR: "It is too funny. You ran in little circles yelling . . . "Oh-God-oh-God-oh-God-oh…."

Silence. Then…

HARRIS: "I think I saw him."

NARRATOR: "Who?"

HARRIS: "Jesus, you dope. *(pause)* You still owe me two pictures."

NARRATOR: "No, I don't."

HARRIS: "You do."

NARRATOR: "Don't."

HARRIS: "Do."

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